



VIPUL SHAH

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Your Daily goes Wherever You do...

On a daily basis, people read either one, or two newspapers, published in their hometown or country, or in the region of their business interests.

Until recently, a traveller could get newspapers from across the world, two days after the day of publication. They were flown in and sold at five star hotel bookshops, airport bookshops, and delivered regularly to companies and embassies. But, post 9/11, this freight has become less attractive to airlines because of the reduction in number of flights and increasing fuel costs. Agreed, that most newspapers are now online, but you don't get them at home, with the same news items and advertisements. Also, vernacular newspapers have a very limited online presence.

In the past two years, two new services have come up to serve this market efficiently—NewsPaperDirect, based in Vancouver and Satellite Newspapers of Netherlands. Both use remote location printing, and give you the publication of your choice at the same time—or even few hours before—it is available in its place of publication. So chances are that someone in Brazil may read the Mumbai edition of the Times of India at the same time as someone in Mumbai, who gets it at seven in the morning.

Both companies offer similar deals. Almost all publications today are prepared using DTP software. Before printing it, a publisher can export these pages to an Adobe Acrobat file, and upload it to NewsPaperDirect and Satellite Newspapers. In 30 minutes, this newspaper will be available world-wide.

NewsPapersDirect is available through the business centres of five star hotels and cruise liners. A small setup of Pentium III PCs, running their proprietary software, with 128 Kbps Internet connectivity and an A3 size laser printer is all that is needed. A fresh installation would cost \$ 8,000, or less. Usually sold for \$ 3 to \$ 5 a piece, part of the money goes to NewsPaperDirect that passes on some money to the concerned publication.

The Taj in Mumbai, the first Indian hotel to offer this facility, has a PC and a laser printer with a 512 Kbps leased line. When-

ever guests order a publication, it is downloaded, printed and delivered to the room in 30 minutes or less. The newspaper's cost starts from Rs 210, and depends on the number of printed pages.

NewsPaperDirect is also used by Qatar Airlines. They are printed and loaded onto the plane before the flight. NewspaperDirect offers 170 publications and on a typical day, prints 2,500 newspapers, and magazines around the world.

Satellite Newspapers have satellite linked kiosks, each with a touch screen for making selections, a credit card swipe slot for accepting payments, and an A3 laser printer that staples and delivers newspapers in few minutes. These are already present in two hotels at New Delhi. Each kiosk costs \$ 10,000 and the newspapers typically cost \$ 4 to \$ 5 a piece. These kiosks will be seen in the future at airports, hotel lobbies, cruise ships, apartment buildings, embassies, etc. Satellite Newspapers carries as many as 120 publications that are limited to 48 pages. The editor decides on the pages to keep; NewspaperDirect doesn't have such a limit.

Both systems are able to limit or customise the newspaper selections made available at a particular place, or kiosks in any country so as to avoid problems with the local authorities, or culture police. Often, a publisher has existing region specific agreements, and hence may not print those newspapers there.

Delivering newspapers overseas, in time, is a logistical nightmare. Using this technology, it can now be done without any printing, paper or transportation costs. The number of copies sold through these systems also account for their audited circulation figures.

The advantages are huge for everyone, and the environment. Since you order and pay to get the newspaper printed, there are no unsold copies. Also, the publisher gets to keep the advertisement money, but doesn't have to handle distribution costs. In the future, when paper-thin flexible displays replace paper in newspaper business, both these infrastructures can serve as single points for the content of several hundred newspapers. ■

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